

The Brass Automaton

Action Plan

June 2026

Pre-launch Checklist

Everything that must be completed before the venue opens to the public.

Task	Owner	Target	Status
Register limited company	Founder	Month 1	Pending
Appoint accountant	Founder	Month 1	Pending
Open business bank account	Founder	Month 1	Pending
Secure venue lease (Shoreditch)	Founder	Month 2	Pending
Engage licensing solicitor	Founder	Month 2	Pending
Apply for premises licence	Solicitor	Month 2	Pending
Apply for alcohol licence	Solicitor	Month 2	Pending
Apply for late night refreshment licence	Solicitor	Month 2	Pending
Apply for PRS/PPL music licence	Manager	Month 3	Pending
Order robotic bartender units (x2)	Founder	Month 2	Pending
Commission custom steampunk casings	Founder	Month 2	Pending
Appoint interior fitout contractor	Founder	Month 2	Pending
Begin steampunk fitout	Contractor	Month 3	Pending
Order bar equipment, POS, kitchen kit	Manager	Month 3	Pending
Set up supplier accounts (spirits, food, beer)	Manager	Month 4	Pending
Hire General Manager	Founder	Month 3	Pending
Hire Bar Supervisor	GM	Month 4	Pending
Design and order staff costumes	GM	Month 4	Pending
Build social media accounts (Instagram, TikTok)	Founder	Month 1	Pending
Create brand identity and logo	Designer	Month 1	Pending
Build website with booking system	Developer	Month 3	Pending
Arrange food hygiene certification	Kitchen lead	Month 5	Pending
Arrange public liability insurance	Founder	Month 4	Pending
Install and test robotic units	Manufacturer	Month 5	Pending
Complete fitout and final inspection	Contractor	Month 5	Pending

Phase 1. Setup (Months 1 to 4)

The first four months are administrative and construction. No revenue is generated. The goal is to have the venue physically ready and all licences approved by the end of Month 4.

Month 1. Register the company. Open business bank account. Appoint accountant. Create brand identity and social media presence. Begin venue search in Shoreditch (secondary options in Camden or Bermondsey).

Month 2. Secure the lease. Engage licensing solicitor and submit all licence applications. Order the two robotic bartender units and commission custom steampunk casings. Appoint fitout contractor and agree the design.

Month 3. Begin the fitout. Order bar equipment, POS system, and kitchen equipment. Hire the General Manager. Build the website with an online booking system. Continue social media content (teaser campaign showing the build progress).

Month 4. Continue fitout. Hire Bar Supervisor. Set up supplier accounts for spirits, food, and beer. Design and order staff costumes. Arrange public liability insurance. The robots should arrive during this period for testing.

Decision Gate (End of Month 4)

Signal	Status	Action
All licences approved, fitout on schedule, robots delivered	GREEN	Proceed to Phase 2
One licence delayed or fitout 2-4 weeks behind	AMBER	Delay soft launch by equivalent time, adjust timeline
Licence refused, fitout contractor failed, robot delivery cancelled	RED	Pause. Reassess feasibility. Do not proceed without resolution.

Critical timing note. If the premises licence is not granted by Month 5 (due to CIZ hearing delays or objections), the soft launch must operate without alcohol and without regulated entertainment after 11pm. This would significantly reduce the value of the soft launch. The licensing solicitor should be engaged in Month 1 to give the application the maximum possible runway.

Month 4. All staff must complete Level 2 Food Hygiene Certificates before soft launch. Kitchen staff should hold Level 3 if possible. All staff must complete allergen awareness training. All staff must be trained on the Challenge 25 age verification policy, fire evacuation procedures, and the noise management and dispersal policies. Prepare written employment contracts for all staff. Contracts must specify night working requirements and comply with Working Time Regulations. Offer free health assessments to all night workers. Arrange a commercial waste collection contract. Register with the ICO for data protection if collecting customer data through the booking system.

Month 3 to 4. Prepare the fire risk assessment (professional assessment, £300 to £500 for a venue of this capacity). Install fire detection and alarm systems, emergency lighting, and fire extinguishers as recommended. Ensure escape routes are clearly marked. Prepare the HACCP food safety management system documentation for the tapas kitchen. Prepare an allergen matrix covering all food items and all cocktails (noting that cocktails can contain allergens through dairy, egg whites, nut liqueurs, and other ingredients). Set up the Challenge 25 age verification policy. Prepare a refusals log. Print Challenge 25 signage for display at the bar and entrance.

Month 3. Commission a robotic bartender risk assessment under PUWER (Provision and Use of Work Equipment Regulations 1998) from a competent assessor with knowledge of robotic systems. This should cover the custom steampunk casings, glass safety panels, emergency stop systems, and any risks from moving parts, hot liquids, or glass handling. Verify that the robotic units carry valid CE or UKCA marking and that the manufacturer's Declaration of Conformity is available. Begin sound proofing works based on the noise impact assessment results (budget £8,000 to £20,000 depending on building construction). Install a noise limiter if required (£500 to £1,500).

Month 2 to 3. Expect the 28 day consultation period for the premises licence. If representations (objections) are made by responsible authorities or local residents, the application will proceed to a licensing committee hearing. The solicitor will represent the business at the hearing. This process can take 4 to 8 weeks after the consultation period closes. Obtain business insurance package covering employer liability (minimum £5 million), public liability (£5 million to £10 million), and product liability specifically covering the robotic bartender equipment. Discuss the robotic units with the insurer to ensure the policy explicitly covers automated cocktail preparation systems. Install a commercial CCTV

system covering all public areas, entrances, exits, and the bar area. System must store images for at least 31 days. This is almost certainly a condition of the premises licence and should be in place before the hearing.

Month 2. Submit the premises licence application to the London Borough of Hackney. The application must include a detailed plan of the premises, the operating schedule, and supporting evidence that the venue will not add to the cumulative impact in the Shoreditch CIZ. This evidence should include proposed conditions (capacity limit, SIA door staff, CCTV, dispersal policy, noise management measures). Commission a noise impact assessment from an acoustic consultant (£1,500 to £3,000). The results will inform sound proofing requirements and may be needed for the premises licence hearing. Register the food business with the local authority (at least 28 days before opening). Apply for PRS for Music and PPL licences for live and recorded music.

Month 1. Owner or General Manager completes a personal licence qualification (one day accredited course, approximately £100 to £200). Submit personal licence application to the local council, including DBS criminal record check. Appoint a licensing solicitor experienced with Cumulative Impact Zone applications in Hackney. The solicitor will advise on the operating schedule, proposed conditions, and how to build the strongest possible case for the premises licence. Begin drafting the premises licence application covering all three licensable activities (sale of alcohol, regulated entertainment for live music, and late night refreshment for tapas after 11pm).

The following legal and regulatory tasks run alongside the operational setup during Phase 1. Several of these are on the critical path. The premises licence, in particular, must be submitted early because the Cumulative Impact Zone process adds significant time.

Legal and Regulatory Tasks (Months 1 to 4)

Phase 2. Soft Launch (Months 5 to 6)

The venue is physically complete. This phase tests everything under real conditions before the public opening.

Month 5. Complete the fitout. Install and test the robotic bartender units under full operating conditions. Hire remaining staff (3 bar staff, 2 kitchen staff, 1 host). Begin staff training on POS system, robot operation, costume protocol, and service standards. Conduct food hygiene certification.

Month 6. Run a 2 to 4 week soft launch. Invite press, food and drink bloggers, local influencers, and friends-of-the-business. Offer reduced pricing during soft launch. Test every menu item. Refine cocktail recipes based on robot performance. Test The Boiler Room package with a live group. Iron out operational issues (queue management, robot throughput, kitchen timing). Collect feedback and adjust.

Decision Gate (End of Month 6)

Signal	Status	Action
Robots reliable, staff trained, positive feedback, operations stable	GREEN	Grand opening. Full marketing push.
Minor robot issues, some menu items need work, operations mostly OK	AMBER	Extend soft launch 2 weeks. Fix issues before public opening.
Robot failures frequent, staff turnover, negative feedback	RED	Do not open publicly. Diagnose root causes. Consider replacing robot supplier.

Phase 3. Grand Opening and Growth (Months 7 to 12)

The bar opens to the public. The focus shifts from building to operating and growing.

Month 7. Grand opening event. Full marketing push across social media, DesignMyNight listing, Time Out listing, Google Business profile. Launch The Boiler Room unlimited drink package. Begin taking group bookings and private event enquiries.

Months 8 to 9. Launch the live music programme (Thursday to Saturday). Focus on building online reviews (Google, TripAdvisor, DesignMyNight). Monitor daily covers and adjust marketing spend if below 50 per day. Introduce the first seasonal menu rotation.

Months 10 to 12. Target 70 to 85 covers per day. Monthly profitability should be achieved by this point (break-even at approximately 59 covers per day). Begin planning for Year 2. Review supplier terms and negotiate volume discounts. Start a waiting list or priority booking system if demand exceeds capacity on weekends.

Decision Gate (End of Month 12)

Signal	Status	Action
Monthly profit positive, 70+ covers/day, strong reviews, brand established	GREEN	Begin Phase 4 planning. Consider robotic waiters and second location research.
Break-even but not profitable, 55-65 covers/day, mixed reviews	AMBER	Focus on retention and marketing. Delay expansion plans. Investigate weak areas.
Below break-even, under 50 covers/day, declining trend	RED	Cut costs. Reassess concept and location. Consider pivoting or closing.

Phase 4. Expansion (Months 13 to 24)

This phase only activates on a GREEN signal from the Month 12 gate. No expansion commitment is made before the pilot is proven.

Months 13 to 15. Introduce 1 to 2 robotic drink delivery units for table service. This is a novelty addition, not a labour replacement. Monitor guest response. If positive, order more units.

Months 16 to 18. Begin researching a second location. Shortlist areas (Camden, Bermondsey, or outside London). Do not commit to a lease until the first venue has been profitable for at least 6 consecutive months.

Months 19 to 24. If a second location is viable, begin lease negotiation and fitout planning. The second venue should follow the same phased launch (soft launch, then grand opening). Consider whether the concept needs adaptation for a different neighbourhood.

Budget Summary

Category	Amount	Notes
Startup Investment	£320,000	Lease, fitout, robots, equipment, stock, licensing, marketing, working capital
Monthly Fixed Costs (Year 1)	£38,050	Rent, staff, music, insurance, utilities, robot maintenance, marketing, admin

Monthly Break-even Revenue	£51,700	At 26.4% blended COGS rate
Break-even Covers per Day	59	At £42 average spend per cover
Year 1 Net Loss (projected)	(£70,200)	Planned loss during ramp-up period
Year 2 Net Profit (projected)	£91,720	First full profitable year
Year 3 Net Profit (projected)	£224,440	At 85 average daily covers